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Gateway to the Top

The National Defence College (NDC) Course is the most prestigious for armed forces officers of one-star rank, as well as officers at the level of joint secretary in the government. Therefore, only the best brigadiers and their equivalents are selected by the armed forces for this year-long course. This is the first formalized teaching imparted to us in our military careers, where the focus during all discussions and deliberations is at the national level. The aim is to enable the future policy-makers to get an overall understanding of the impact of international, regional and national issues relating to national security, and a focused exposure to political, military, economic and scientific dimensions that are vital for evolving national strategies. Besides this, the course is an excellent opportunity to interact with officers from the armed forces of friendly foreign countries. The highlights of the course are talks given by a vast array of experts, intellectuals and specialists in diverse fields; tours within India and to foreign countries; and presentations on India by study groups of students.

I was fortunate to visit the USA and Poland during the foreign tour in mid-1993. Post Cold War, we were the first students from the NDC course who were allowed to visit the USA. Our programme included interactions with the department of defence officials in the Pentagon, a visit to an airbase in Virginia, where we saw the F-7 stealth fighter from very close, and we were also taken on board the nuclear-powered aircraft carrier, USS John F. Kennedy, at the naval base in Norfolk. It was amazing to learn that the nuclear power plant on the carrier could light up a small town. During the interaction at the Pentagon, I raised the issue of double standards